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In Sight

Renovating The Office

Microsoft Office 12 Beta explored...

Ahmed Shaikh

How many of us have used Microsoft Word beyond the most basic of its features? Mail Merge, Citations, Watermarks, Themes, Cross-references, Hyperlinks, and Cover Pages—do you know what your favourite Word processor can do? The first version of Microsoft's seminal Word processor shipped with 100 features; Microsoft Office Word 2003 has a total of 1,500. One thousand and five hundred commands hidden behind a jungle of menus—it is very easy to miss the leaves for the forest. Indeed, by Microsoft's own admission, users consistently ask the software company to add features that are already present in the suite—just invisible to us common folks.

If there ever was a product that was guilty of feature overload to the detriment of productivity, it would be the current version of Microsoft Office. A look at the screenshot on next page—*The current version of Word with all toolbars enabled*—highlights this in a striking manner. And this is just the toolbars; let's not forget the layers upon layers of menus.

The solution isn't a pruning of features, but rather a smarter presentation of everything that Office can already do. Microsoft is aware of this, and has implemented, in Office 12, what it hopes is something that will expose the capabilities of its Office suite

in a clean and intelligent manner. Here, we take a look at what the solution entails and whether it is a step in the right direction. Note that this article is based on Beta software; as such, things are likely to change.

Working In Tasks

Over the past few years, Microsoft has been experimenting with task-based interfaces. These are most visible under Windows XP's Explorer: browsing the My Pictures folder, for example, will allow you to do Picture Tasks and File and Folder Tasks. You can do tasks pertaining to an image—such as printing, e-mailing, or setting a photo as a desktop background. Such an approach allows you to print a photograph without the need to know which application

Illustration Chaitanya Surpur